

FARMERS SET DRIP IRRIGATION
LINES IN THEIR FIELDS



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A Green RISING

Government-public initiatives in Gujarat pack a lesson in groundwater management for the entire country by blending indigenous methods with modern technologies

By Uday Mahurkar

That India is on the verge of a serious water crisis is a foregone conclusion. So much so that the possibility of water riots in the future can't be ruled out. And it's not that the farmers of Vidarbha in Maharashtra or Bundelkhand in Uttar Pradesh are the only casualties of depleting groundwater level. In satellite townships like Gurgaon and state capitals like Hyderabad, the situation is much worse than the rest of the country. And the blame doesn't go to bad monsoons alone. More than indifferent monsoons, this scarcity of water has



“To get something from mother earth you have to give something back. If you don't, it will stop giving you. It's not a one-way cycle.”

NARENDRA MODI, *Chief Minister Gujarat*

been caused by over exploitation of groundwater and lack of water conservation measures at the micro level.

The answer to this monumental challenge that stares at an otherwise resurgent India comes from Gujarat. The state shows the way in the form of a unique government-people partnership model for water conservation. There results are here to see. In 2004, the water table of 112 tehsils of the total 225 tehsils in Gujarat was in semi-critical to over-exploited condition. But a satellite based survey done last year by the Central Ground Water Board (CGWB) found that as many as 60 of these 112 tehsils have regained their